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SHIFT
BY MENA FINTECH ASSOCIATION
PAYMENTS COMMITTEE

AGENTIC COMMERCE

Practical Implementation Landscape, Ecosystem Strategies and Strategic Implications



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About MENA Fintech Association and SHIFT Payments

The MENA Fintech Association (MFTA) is a not-for-profit organization dedicated to fostering collaboration and innovation across the financial technology ecosystem in the Middle East and North Africa. Through its regional network of regulators, financial institutions, startups, investors, and technology providers, MFTA works to advance policy dialogue, promote responsible innovation, and support the development of inclusive financial systems.

As part of this mission, the SHIFT Payments Working Group serves as a collaborative platform focused on modernizing payment infrastructure and accelerating the adoption of interoperable, secure, and inclusive payment solutions across the region. The Working Group brings together industry experts and stakeholders to address key challenges, share best practices, and develop actionable recommendations that support the evolution of digital payments and financial inclusion in MENA.



Stanislav Ismagilov

— Author

Senior Payments Advisor, 237 Ventures,
Former Senior Leader, Visa

Stanislav Ismagilov is a Senior Payments Advisor at 237 Ventures with more than 25 years of international experience in banking, card payments, product strategy, and digital financial services. He previously held senior leadership roles at Visa and Alfa-Bank, where he led payments growth and retail banking transformation initiatives across Central and Eastern Europe, the Middle East, and Africa (CEMEA). Stanislav advises banks, fintechs, and ecosystem stakeholders on payment innovation, strategic partnerships, and financial inclusion.



Clyde Rosanowski

Board Advisor | Payments Futurist |
Builder of the Next Commerce Layer

Co-Chair, MFTA SHIFT Payments Working Group



Akshay Chopra

Fintech, Investor, Inventor, Author,
Board Director | 237 Ventures

Co-Chair, MFTA SHIFT Payments Working Group

1. Overview

Agentic commerce is moving from concept to controlled production. The key shift is not that AI can recommend products. It is that AI agents can increasingly discover, compare, select, reserve, pay and trigger fulfillment under authority the user has already granted.

Agentic commerce is the operating model in which software agents, usually AI-driven, complete or materially advance commercial workflows on behalf of consumers or businesses. It differs from traditional e-commerce because the customer no longer has to manually search, compare, fill forms and complete checkout. It also differs from conversational commerce because the conversation does not merely produce a recommendation. It can lead to a real transaction, provided that authorization, payment credentials and merchant accountability are handled safely.

In this model, the agent becomes a first-class participant in the journey from discovery to checkout and post-purchase, supported by interoperable APIs, identity and authorization rails, and protected payment credentials.

2. The Four-Layer Architecture

The practical architecture has four layers.

- The ***intent layer*** captures what the user wants: budget, timing, preferences, brand constraints, delivery window, loyalty preference or risk tolerance.
- The ***agency layer*** converts that intent into actions: searching, comparing, building a basket, choosing an offer, calling APIs and handling exceptions.
- The ***transaction layer*** authorizes the action, protects credentials, routes payment and confirms merchant acceptance.
- The ***accountability layer*** creates evidence: who authorized the agent, what the agent was permitted to do, what merchant accepted the order, which payment instrument was used and who is responsible if something goes wrong.

Layer	Key Players
Intent Layer	OpenAI / ChatGPT, Google AI Mode / Gemini, Perplexity, Amazon Shopping app
Agency Layer	OpenAI ACP, Google UCP, Alibaba Accio Work, Amazon Buy for Me, PayPal–Google Cloud agent
Transaction Layer	Mastercard Agent Pay, Visa Intelligent Commerce, Stripe, PayPal, Alipay AI Pay
Accountability Layer	Mastercard Agent Pay Framework, Visa IC Consent Flow, Google Agent Payments Protocol, PayPal Buyer Protection, Stripe ACP

The economic promise is straightforward: reduce friction between intent and purchase. The user should not have to move from search to website to product page to cart to login to payment to tracking. The agent should compress that journey.

That compression creates real risks. If a human no longer clicks every step, the industry must prove authorization, prevent credential exposure, distinguish legitimate agents from malicious bots, preserve merchant accountability and manage disputes. This is why the most serious players are not simply launching chatbots. They are building identity, tokenization, consent, merchant control and post-purchase governance into the transaction flow from the start.

3. How Ecosystem Players Are Shaping Agentic Commerce

Mastercard: Trusted Agentic Payments as a Network Layer

Mastercard's approach is to make AI-initiated payments safe, recognizable and scalable across the existing card ecosystem. Its product umbrella is Mastercard Agent Pay. Strategically, Mastercard is not trying to own the shopping interface. It is trying to ensure that when an AI agent initiates a transaction, that transaction can still be trusted by the consumer, merchant, issuer and acquirer.

The Mastercard model is built around three ideas. First, agents should be trusted and identifiable, not anonymous bots. Second, agent-initiated payments should use tokenized credentials and authentication rather than exposing raw card data. Third, merchants should be able to accept agentic payments without major technical redevelopment.

The most practical expression of this strategy is the Mastercard and PayPal partnership, announced in October 2025. Mastercard Agent Pay will be integrated into PayPal's wallet, allowing AI agents to complete transactions on behalf of PayPal users. PayPal will also pilot Mastercard's Agent Pay Acceptance Framework and test compatibility with common agentic protocols, AI agent verification and data exchange. Mastercard brings network trust; PayPal brings wallet reach, vaulted credentials, buyer familiarity and millions of merchants.

Visa: Intelligent Commerce as a Trust and Enablement Layer

Visa's approach is similar in ambition but different in emphasis. Visa is positioning Visa Intelligent Commerce as a trust layer and enablement platform that lets AI agents transact safely on Visa rails. The approach combines tokenization, identity, risk controls, passkey-based authentication and agent identity protocols.

In April 2026, Visa announced Intelligent Commerce Connect, described as a network, protocol and token vault agnostic on-ramp to agentic commerce for agent builders, merchants and enablers. Regardless of which AI surface or commerce protocol scales, Visa wants to be the trusted payment and credential layer underneath.

Visa's pilots with agent-enabling partners in the US include consumer and B2B purchases. In Europe, Visa's Agentic Ready program supports issuer-led testing of agent-initiated payments using tokenization, identity, risk and controls.

PayPal: Wallet Trust, Merchant Enablement and Cross-Platform Commerce

PayPal is taking one of the most commercially practical approaches because it already controls a trusted wallet, authentication flows, buyer protection, dispute handling and a large merchant base. Its global agentic commerce strategy has three pillars.

First, PayPal launched agentic commerce services in October 2025. These include merchant discoverability, store sync and an agent-ready payment solution. PayPal says this will allow millions of existing merchants to accept payments on AI surfaces, with fraud detection, buyer protection and dispute resolution, without additional technical lift.

Second, PayPal is partnering with Perplexity to turn the AI answer engine into a shopping and checkout surface. In this model, Perplexity captures intent and product discovery, while PayPal handles wallet-based checkout, identity, payment confidence and post-purchase trust.

Third, PayPal is working with Google Cloud on merchant-owned agentic commerce. PayPal and Google Cloud are enabling merchants to deploy branded conversational commerce agents on their own digital surfaces, while PayPal powers payments. The PayPal agent communicates with the merchant's agent through Agent2Agent protocol and integrates with Google's Agent Payments Protocol, which provides trust, accountability and fraud controls.

OpenAI and Stripe: The AI Interface Becomes a Storefront

OpenAI's strategy is to convert ChatGPT from an advice and discovery surface into a commerce surface. Its key product is Instant Checkout in ChatGPT, powered by the Agentic Commerce Protocol co-developed with Stripe. OpenAI explicitly states that merchants remain in control of the customer relationship as a merchant of record, including fulfillment, returns, support and communication.

Stripe announced that US ChatGPT users can buy from US-based Etsy merchants directly in chat, with Shopify merchants planned. Stripe uses a Shared Payment Token model so payment credentials are not exposed to the agent or merchant in raw form.

The strategic significance is worth stating plainly. OpenAI controls consumer intent. Stripe controls payment infrastructure. Merchants retain fulfillment and customer obligations. This is the clearest example of AI-interface-first commerce currently in production.

Amazon: Marketplace Extension Through Buy for Me

Amazon's Buy for Me is one of the more strategically provocative implementations. The service is live in beta in the Amazon Shopping app for a subset of US customers. It allows shoppers to discover and buy products from external brand websites when Amazon does not sell the item directly. The user stays in the Amazon app, confirms address, tax, shipping and payment, and Amazon's AI securely provides encrypted details to the brand's website.

Products available through Buy for Me grew from 65,000 at launch to more than half a million, indicating real expansion. For merchants, this creates a new form of intermediation: the brand fulfills and services the order, while Amazon owns the discovery and transaction moment.

Google: Protocol, Search, Gemini and Merchant Data

Google is shaping agentic commerce through Universal Commerce Protocol, Google AI Mode, Gemini, Merchant Center and Google Pay. Its approach covers the full shopping journey, not just checkout.

Google says UCP is an open standard for agentic commerce across discovery, buying and post-purchase support, designed to create a common language between agents, systems, businesses and payment providers. UCP was co-developed with Shopify, Etsy, Wayfair, Target and Walmart and endorsed by more than 20 ecosystem players including Visa, Mastercard, PayPal, Stripe and others.

For merchants, Google's proposition is practical: integrate UCP, remain merchant of record, keep customer data and relationships, use existing Merchant Center feeds, and enable agentic actions on Google AI Mode and Gemini starting with direct buying.

Alibaba B2B: Agentic Commerce as Enterprise Operations

Alibaba's B2B approach is different from consumer checkout. Its international commerce division launched Accio Work, a plug-and-play AI taskforce for SMEs that can autonomously run complex business operations. Reuters reported that Alibaba positions Accio Work as a specialized B2B tool rather than a generalist consumer platform.

Much of agentic commerce will not be consumer shopping. It will be B2B procurement, supplier comparison, invoice processing, inventory replenishment, logistics coordination, purchase-order preparation and payment approval. Alibaba is building toward agentic business operations, not just buying a product in chat.

4. MENA Landscape

The MENA region is one of the most commercially significant markets in the global agentic commerce story. The MENA B2C e-commerce market is currently estimated at 50 billion dollars and is projected to exceed that by 2026. Saudi Arabia's e-commerce sector alone is growing at a CAGR of 26.4 percent through 2033. These figures position MENA not as a regional footnote but as a primary deployment market for the next wave of agentic commerce.

Key Data Point

58 percent of UAE consumers are already using generative AI tools, outpacing UK and European markets. 80 percent of regional organizations are under strong pressure to adopt AI (Deloitte Middle East, 2026 AI Trends Report). These figures explain why global networks selected the UAE as their first market outside the US.

UAE: An Early Implementation Market

The UAE is currently one of the world's most visible early markets for agentic commerce. Its combination of high digital adoption, government-led AI strategy and advanced payment infrastructure made it the natural first destination for global pilots outside the United States.

Mastercard, Majid Al Futtaim and Dataiera

Mastercard introduced Agent Pay in the UAE in November 2025, marking its first transaction outside the US. The pilot was launched with Majid Al Futtaim and fintech Dataiera, in the presence of H.E. Omar Sultan Al Olama. The use case was intentionally bounded: cardholders would use an AI agent to search, discover and transact, including booking theatre tickets at VOX Cinemas.

This is a classic Mastercard-style pilot: merchant ecosystem plus fintech partner plus network trust layer. The practical value is not that cinema tickets are commercially complex. It is that they are operationally safe for early validation. Tickets are low-variance, digitally delivered, time-bound and easier to reverse or service than many physical goods. Early agentic commerce will likely scale first in bounded categories such as tickets, reservations, fees, renewals and repeat purchases.

Visa, Aldar and Emirates NBD

The Visa implementation with Aldar is commercially different. It is not a retail discovery use case. It is an operational payment use case. The first transaction involved paying real estate service charges through an AI agent in the Live Aldar app using an Emirates NBD Darna Visa Credit Card. It was the first live implementation of Visa Intelligent Commerce in the region, with a consent-led flow and payment completion within seconds.

"Agentic commerce is moving from concept to execution in the UAE faster than most expected, and the conversation has shifted from experimentation to trust, governance and scale. As AI agents begin to search, decide and transact on behalf of users, the payments layer has to be ready for that responsibility. At Visa, we are building that layer through Visa Intelligent Commerce: tokenization, passkeys and privacy-by-design controls that let agents act autonomously without exposing credentials or bypassing authorization. This is already live. With Aldar, we completed the first real agentic commerce transaction in the Middle East. With Inception, a G42 company, we are integrating these capabilities into advanced AI agent environments across the region. The technology is moving. The harder work now is earning consumer trust and making sure that scale does not outrun governance."

— Yuri Topunov, VP and Head of Products and Solutions for MENA, Visa

Visa and Inception / G42

Visa's partnership with Inception, a G42 company, is an ecosystem and capability-building partnership. Inception will integrate Visa Intelligent Commerce into agentic commerce solutions for merchants, issuers, marketplaces and ecosystem partners across CEMEA. The parties will co-develop agent-based commerce capabilities and support pilot programs, client demonstrations and ecosystem-readiness efforts. This is Visa's UAE and CEMEA approach: combine a local advanced-AI platform with Visa's payment trust infrastructure.

Saudi Arabia: Infrastructure-Led Readiness

Saudi Arabia is not yet publicly documented as having a live agentic commerce transaction comparable to the UAE pilots. Its approach is more infrastructure-led, which is consistent with how Saudi Arabia has developed its payment market: build national rails, scale digital payments, integrate wallets and then allow AI-led commerce to emerge on top.

Saudi Arabia Payment Data

SAMA reported 12.6 billion non-cash transactions in 2024, representing 79 percent of all retail payments. Contactless adoption reached 98 percent, up from just 4 percent in 2017 (Middle East Briefing). These figures demonstrate that Saudi Arabia has already achieved the consumer behavior and merchant acceptance needed to support agentic commerce.

The Kingdom's path is likely to run through mada, wallets, tourism payments, marketplace integrations and merchant enablement. The launch of Google Pay in Saudi Arabia and the announced Alipay+ acceptance through mada by 2026 are enabling moves. AI agents need tokenized credentials, wallet acceptance, machine-readable merchants and payment rails that can process delegated transactions under user controls.

Mastercard's Saudi commentary describes agentic commerce as the next frontier where AI agents proactively discover and purchase products, while Mastercard Agent Pay brings multi-layered security, rules and standards to create transparency in agent-driven payments.

Qatar: Retailer-Led, Backend-First and Human-in-the-Loop

Qatar's agentic commerce narrative is different from both the UAE and Saudi Arabia. It is not primarily a payment-network pilot or a national-rail strategy. It is being discussed through the lens of retail operations. Dr Mohamed Althaf, Global Director of LuLu Group, has argued that Qatar's digital infrastructure, young demographics and high-income economy could allow it to leapfrog directly into AI-driven retail, noting in regional reporting from early 2025 that the opportunity is most immediate in backend and B2B use cases: logistics, receiving, inventory management, supplier processes and operational compliance.

LuLu's strategy, as described in regional reporting, draws on active use of AI in cold chain management, IoT energy systems and predictive analytics, as well as plans for Qatar's first robotic fulfillment centre. One observation from that reporting is worth noting directly: agents do not browse, pause at displays or read marketing copy. They execute parameters. Products that are not machine-visible may disappear from consideration entirely.

Qatar may therefore become a strong case for agentic retail infrastructure rather than consumer-facing agentic checkout. In this model, the early wins are food-waste reduction, inventory precision, supplier coordination, compliance and B2B automation. Payments will follow once operational agents are trusted.

MENA Strategic Argument

GCC enterprises carry significantly less legacy technology debt than Western counterparts. Combined with government-led AI strategies and sovereign data frameworks, this positions the GCC not as a follower of global agentic commerce trends but as a production market for the next wave of deployment (TahawulTech: The Agentic Leap in the GCC).

5. Fraud and Risk in Agentic

The accountability layer is one of the four foundations of agentic commerce, and it is already under pressure. Commercetools reported a 450 percent spike in dark web activity around AI agent fraud tools during Q4 2025. This is directly relevant to the UAE and Saudi Arabia pilots currently in operation and must be considered by any compliance or risk function evaluating agentic commerce readiness.

If a human no longer clicks every step of a transaction, the industry must prove authorization, prevent credential exposure, distinguish legitimate agents from malicious bots, preserve merchant accountability and manage disputes. The most serious players are not simply launching chatbots. They are building identity, tokenization, consent, merchant control and post-purchase governance into the transaction flow precisely because the fraud surface is expanding.

For banks, merchants and payment networks operating in MENA, the strategic question is not only which layer to control, but how to govern it. Tokenization, registered agent identities, consent frameworks and post-purchase audit trails are not optional features. They are prerequisites for operating safely at scale.

6. A Reference Point: China and Alipay AI Pay

Agentic commerce is developing quickly in the US and Europe. The US is leading on AI-interface commerce through OpenAI, Stripe, PayPal, Perplexity, Amazon and Google. Europe is moving through bank and issuer readiness, including Visa's Agentic Ready program and Mastercard's bank-led demonstrations. The GCC, especially the UAE, is clearly at the forefront outside the US because it has already hosted named, live or controlled agentic commerce implementations.

For scale context, Alipay AI Pay surpassed 100 million users in February 2026 and processed more than 120 million transactions during a single week in February 2026. It also extended AI Pay to agent-type use cases, allowing users to activate Alipay payment inside an agent, complete identity verification, state a need, confirm the order and authorize payment.

The reason Alipay can scale faster is structural. It already controls a dense wallet, identity, mini-program and merchant ecosystem. Visa, Mastercard, Stripe, PayPal, OpenAI and Google must coordinate across multiple parties. Alipay compresses more of the value chain into one ecosystem.

7. Strategic Implications

Agentic commerce will not have one winner. It will be split across intent owners, trust providers, wallets, merchant platforms, marketplaces and protocol layers. The players that win will be those that control at least two of the following four layers: consumer intent, product data, payment authorization and post-purchase trust.

For banks, merchants and payment networks, the strategic question is no longer whether agentic commerce will happen. It is which layer they will control when AI becomes the default interface between intent and transaction.

For the MENA region specifically, the opportunity is larger than simply participating in global pilots. The structural advantages are real: low legacy debt, high digital adoption, government commitment to AI, and sovereign data frameworks. The GCC is positioned not as a market that adopts trends from elsewhere but as a market where the next generation of agentic commerce will be built and validated first.

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